

proved another heartbreaker for the 35-year-old Bulgarian, who was touted as 'Baby Fed' early in his career for his athletic and stylistic resemblance to Federer. A year ago, Dimitrov built a stunning 6-3, 7-5, 2-2 lead against eventual champion Sinner before injuring his pectoral muscle and writhing in pain. For the fifth Major in a row, Dimitrov was forced to retire.

This year, the favoured Dimitrov suffered a less cruel but still disappointing fate. With boisterous British fans cheering every Fery point won and gasping at every point lost, and Federer watching from the Royal Box, Dimitrov was twice up a service break in the fourth set.

But the dogged Fery battled back to take the set and eventually forced a fifth-set match tie-break. As the drama reached its climax, the crowd grew louder and louder. With the local lad down 6-5, was his Cinderella run about to end?

The baby-faced assassin, not the least bit intimidated on his Centre Court debut, rallied to prevail 7-5, 3-6, 4-6, 6-4, 7-6(7) to make a Slam quarterfinal for the first time. "The support was phenomenal," an ecstatic Fery told the still-cheering crowd. "Five sets against an absolute legend. I grew up five minutes from here, watching matches on this court. Yeah, it's unbelievable. It's a dream of mine."

The dream run continued with a sensational rout of Cobolli, after which he said, "It gets better and better every match. I just can't believe it." If that weren't exhilarating enough, Queen Camilla exchanged pleasantries with Fery afterwards. "She congratulated me. I told her how much of an honour it was for me to play in front of her. She just said, 'Congratulations, keep going.' I told her it was my birthday on Sunday, so it would be great to play the Wimbledon final on my birthday."

Alas, such a wonderful scenario was not to be. In a David-vs-Goliath semifinal, with luminaries including Hugh Laurie, Dustin Hoffman and Sachin Tendulkar in the Royal Box, the towering Zverev crushed Fery 7-6(0), 6-2, 6-4. With 135 mph serves



streaking past — and sometimes above — Fery, who has an average bounce height of 5'3", the German set the tone with what McEnroe called "the most impressive tiebreaker you'll ever see".

The lopsided victory gave Zverev an outstanding 18-1 record in Majors this year as he became the first German to make the Wimbledon final since Boris Becker in 1995 and the 13th man in the Open Era to reach all four Grand Slam finals.

"Sascha has improved his second serve and forehand so much, and his volley," said former No. 1 Jim Courier. "He was roping inside-out forehands in triple digits."

Landmark victory: At 21, Linda Noskova etched her name into history as the youngest Wimbledon champion since Petra Kvitova's triumph in 2011.

AFP

Zverev had lost three of his previous four Major finals. But would his career-changing Roland Garros title free him to again unleash all his potent weapons and be braver, as Nadal advised?

Before the championship match, Zverev said, "I'm getting older. I'm getting better. I have to trust myself."

For nearly two sets, Sascha did just that, until he didn't, faltering yet again against his nemesis, Sinner.